A fascinating medium of expression

MADRAS

A puppet peeps out. Strikingly gay and hopelessly funny. Laughter. The old join the young. Another puppet walks by. Starched and formal, carrying a placard that warns: "Smoking hurts you". Yet another looks more like a creature from our future. Sputnik in one hand and the Mars in the other. Enough to hold the puppet "classroom" in awe. The fourth resembles a social crusader.

Puppetry has indeed come a long way since its origin some 2,000 years ago in the heartland of India. String puppets were used to tell the greatness of Vikramaditya or Prithviraj Chauhan. In the South, leather puppets traced the history and times of the Satavahanas through their "Bommalattam". It was later that glove puppets and rod puppets appeared to highlight epics like the Ramayana and the Mahabharata not only here, but in faraway places like Java, Sumatra, Japan and China. Trade was one route that helped to carry it across the seas.

But in times that we now live in, this fascinating medium of expression can be strengthened and spread through workshops. One such — an eight-day affair — is now in progress at the Guild of Service in Madras. Being conducted by Mr. Ajay Paul of the Community Puppet Theatre in Udaipur and sponsored by the Crafts Council of India and the Tamil Nadu Joint Action Council for Women, the workshop has 29 participation in it. Twenty-five are women.

And why so? As someone in the crowd said, the women would like to attain perfection in "handling puppets". Are the men listening? But most others had conventional views on why they were there. A man from the Air Force felt that puppetry would be entertaining in an SOS village that he was associated with. A community worker hoped to teach Nature to her people with the help of "katputhlis". A coconut tree could whisper to a mango tree and maybe beckon a banyan tree. Or, two puppets could be strolling in a garden discussing the vanishing green. A school teacher from Kottur planned to delight her students with puppet lessons. Most subjects would come alive this way.

Even arithmetic, history, science and language, stressed Mr. Paul. "We can teach simple addition and subtraction to three-year-olds with the help of a mother duck and her ducklings. All in puppet form. Such a visually rich fare will help children to grasp faster and retain longer... Imparting science in senior classes can be a challenge for puppetry. For example, how do you teach them the meaning of gravity or the method of determining distances between the planets. This is where shadow puppetry comes in. You can produce the reflection of just about anything."

More interesting, and perhaps important, puppetry can herald social changes. It can set a man thinking. Some years ago, 400-odd people queued up to get themselves vaccinated after they had seen a puppet play about the dangers of smallpox in their village. On the outskirts of Udaipur, labourers forced their contractor to pay them their lawful wages when Mr. Paul contrived a similar situation through his puppets. These little dolls told an audience of labourers that they should fight for a just cause. "What appeared to become a miserable Holi, with wages unpaid, turned out to be brilliantly colourful", Mr. Paul. Yes, the contractor had chosen the festive period to twist arms.



Mr. Ajay Paul at his workshop on puppets.

The question that would arise here is: can puppetry survive to carry out these functions in the face of especially television? "It still has a large rural audience. In the cities, children below ten love watching it. Those older may not, preferring to keep themselves glued to television sets. But on the whole, man enjoys watching his miniature (puppet) do things that he himself would have liked to.

"However, unlike man, the puppet has no ego. It can tackle subjects that an actor might find too delicate to..... puppetry is adaptable. Unlike a film, a cartoon or a written work, wording or the details of a situation can be altered time and again. It was the habit of the old, travelling puppet shows in Germany to send a man in advance to a village where they would be performing. By the time the show got there, it was topical and personal. The puppets knew the names of the blacksmith and the baker", Mr. Paul would have continued with his story, but for the interruption by one of the participants who wanted to know if the model of the "rakshas" she has made was good enough.

Making of a puppet, dressing it up and decorating it with ornaments are part of what is being taught at the workshop. The actual handling of one and finally the show, which is planned for Sunday in a nearby village, may prove to be more exciting. Yet, not quite, when we see puppetry from some of the East European countries, France, England, Japan and China. Japanese and Chinese puppets are so large that you require three men to handle one. The puppet themes in Poland are moving, and the Judy-Punch team from England run riot. Somewhere, this cadre of puppetry has slowed down. — Madras Staff Reporter

The Hindu/13-02-1987/17